

## Halo Effect

### What is it?

A positive first impression in one area influences how people judge everything else about a product, person, or brand.

If one part looks good, people assume the rest is also good.

### History

First defined by psychologist Edward Thorndike in 1920.

Later studies in cognitive science and behavioral psychology reinforced that humans rely on fast first-impression shortcuts to reduce mental effort.

### The Psychology Behind It

- Brain prioritizes fast judgement to avoid cognitive conflict
- One positive trait biases how we perceive the entire object
- Negative first impressions create the opposite side (Horn Effect)
- We subconsciously want our first belief to remain consistent

### Why It Matters

- Creates unrealistic expectations
- Users overlook flaws
- Can distort fair comparisons
- Drives positive word-of-mouth

### How to Apply It

- Craft strong first impressions (UI polish, onboarding)
- Keep claims realistic and honest
- Use unbiased reviews to balance perception
- Maintain consistent quality across the full journey

### Theory in Action

- Apple: premium perception spreads across all products even if one item has flaws
- Disney: positive theme park experience influences perception of movies, merch, and cruises

### Final Thought

Halo Effect helps users make snap judgments.

But if you don't continue delivering quality, the effect fades fast.